

Britain | A man with a plan

Reform UK tries to get serious

But Robert Jenrick's mission to professionalise the populists is incomplete

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ROBERT JENRICK was once a Conservative Party minister so blandly on-message that he was cruelly nicknamed “Robert Generic”. Yet he defected to the populist-right Reform UK in January after turning into a strident critic of immigration and enthusiastic participant in Britain’s culture wars, hitting out at human-rights laws and the pro-Palestinian movement.

His shift looks like a symbol of how the right has hardened since Brexit (which he opposed). Former Tory colleagues charge him with pure opportunism: Mr Jenrick left his old party after being beaten to the leadership by Kemi Badenoch, and was swiftly appointed Reform’s treasury spokesman. He is spoken of as a possible successor to the party’s leader, Nigel Farage.

In Mr Jenrick's telling it is the Tories who have changed, not he. He points out that, in office, they raised government spending and taxes, failed to deregulate and let net migration hit record highs. He sees his role as helping Reform evolve from a party of protest—its fiscal plans at the last general election were wildly unrealistic—into an outfit ready for power.

Reform is already looking somewhat more serious. A £90bn (\$122bn) splurge on tax cuts has been abandoned, as have mutterings about nationalising water and energy. On August 17th Mr Jenrick laid out its most detailed and credible policy offering yet: a plan to overhaul the welfare system in order to reverse a surge in payments to those judged too sick to work, or who face extra costs because of disability or illness.

Reform's policy would cut £50bn from the benefits bill—more than a third of the total now paid to working-age adults—by limiting regular cash payments to only the neediest, pushing employers to support workers who are off sick for up to two years and blocking non-British citizens from claiming most benefits. It is the most comprehensive proposal any party has put forward to reform welfare (Labour is expected to present its own version by the end of the year). Charlotte Pickles of Re:State, a think-tank, says it is “a serious piece of work” backed by comprehensive accounting of its costs and savings.

Still, the policy contains potential pitfalls. The £50bn headline figure could be eroded by changes in claimants' behaviour: for example, foreigners who have lived in Britain for some time but not bothered to claim citizenship may do so rather than risk losing their benefits. And stripping welfare from EU nationals who have lived in Britain since before Brexit will require renegotiating a treaty with the bloc. It is hard to imagine European leaders being keen to do any favours for a Reform-led government. It would also be politically tricky to implement such sharp cuts with no transition period for those affected.

Speaking to *The Economist*, Mr Jenrick says he is rolling out an economic policy that will present a contrast to Andy Burnham's statism and Ms Badenoch's free-market purism. "Reform differentiates itself from others in that it's genuinely a workers' party," he claims. "It is about helping working people, and the retired people who have worked hard their whole lives. Our policies are aimed at them—not Benefits Street or the rich in Belgravia."

He is expected to give a speech soon to make the case for a "post-Thatcherite" economy, offering cuts to business costs and regulations—including abandoning carbon-emissions targets—along with an industrial policy which protects sectors like carmaking and ceramics. Reform has so far resisted the temptation to allocate the savings from its promised spending squeeze to tax cuts. Any future tax cuts are more likely to involve reducing levies on work than previous Reform priorities such as abolishing inheritance tax, which would disproportionately benefit richer people.

Mr Jenrick's impact on his new party goes only so far, however. He is not popular with voters, says Luke Tryl of More in Common, a pollster; even Reform supporters rate him below other senior figures. The party refuses to take on some of Britain's thorniest problems, such as the need to curb spending on pensioner benefits and challenge NIMBYS who block the building of new homes in the countryside.

And while the party may be getting more sensible on some areas, it still looks shambolic. Mr Farage spent the summer fighting an unnecessary by-election to win back the seat he resigned in a fit of pique over claims (which he denies) that he has been evasive about his finances. Reform's handful of well-known personalities can rarely resist taking rhetorical potshots at each other in public: this week Tim Montgomerie, a conservative commentator, was suspended from the party after falling out with colleagues. Just one in six voters say they believe it is the party best placed to run Britain's economy. Mr Jenrick's "project professional" has a long way to go. ■